

What Happened to Patients Like Me?



Imagine you've just been diagnosed with cancer.

Your doctor recommends a treatment that may be painful, take months, have significant side effects, and be very expensive.

The message, simplified, is:

“This is the treatment I recommend. It won't be easy, but trust me.”

Your doctor may cite clinical studies and success rates. But were those patients really like you? How much experience does this physician have treating patients with your condition and characteristics? What were the outcomes? Is there a newer or better alternative?

So you and your family search the Internet.

There you find someone who appears to have had the same condition. Instead of enduring the recommended treatment, this person describes an herbal, dietary, homeopathic, or other alternative:

“This worked for me. It could work for you.”

The testimonial may be completely honest. But was the person's condition really like yours? Were other treatments involved? How many people tried it without improving? Did the alternative actually cause the improvement?

The physician and the Internet testimonial clearly don't offer equivalent evidence.

But they leave the patient facing the same fundamental question:

What happened to patients like me?

Healthcare already generates enormous amounts of information about patients, conditions, treatments, and procedures. What it frequently fails to capture and connect is:

Patient → Condition → Treatment → Outcome

Imagine being able to compare outcomes from large numbers of patients with similar conditions and relevant characteristics—including the treatments they received and what happened afterward.

That shouldn't replace physician judgment. It could give physicians and patients better evidence to guide that judgment.

And it could help distinguish complementary and alternative treatments that provide benefit from those that do nothing—or interfere with effective care.

Perhaps the question facing a frightened patient shouldn't have to be:

“Whom do I trust?”

It could become:

“What happened to patients like me?”

The right information. In time. Every time.

FHIA-09 is part of the Future Healthcare Information Architecture series:

doungebel.github.io/HealthcareAI